

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 2.1

RHYTHM

BASIC DEFINITIONS:
MEASURES, TEMPO,
COMMON AND CUT TIME



SIMPLE AND COMPOUND METERS

In the previous lesson we introduced the concept of measures and bar lines. (Unit 1.1, Slide 11)
When the pulse or beat is organized into regularly measured units (measures) separated by bar lines, we identify them by means of a time signature, such as $\frac{2}{4}$ or $\frac{3}{4}$. Practically speaking this means that the first beat after the bar line is given more emphasis, while the ones that follow receive less emphasis. Counting in $\frac{2}{4}$ sounds like this:

ONE - two | ONE - two | ONE - two | ONE - two |, whereas in $\frac{3}{4}$ it would sound:

ONE - two -three | ONE - two -three | ONE - two -three | ONE - two -three |

These are called **simple meters**, because, like prime numbers, they are not divisible into smaller units. Other examples of simple meters would be $\frac{2}{2}$ and $\frac{3}{2}$.

On the other hand, a meter such as $\frac{4}{4}$ is called a **compound meter**, because within each measure there is a subdivision of emphasis:

ONE - two - THREE - four | ONE - two - THREE - four | ONE - two - THREE - four

with the ONE being stronger than the THREE.

- **Quick Exercise:**

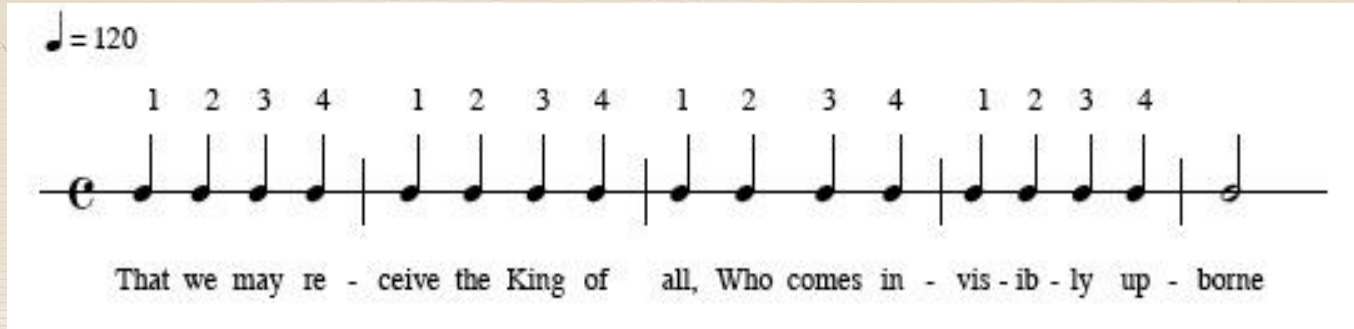
- Keeping a steady pulse, count out 8 measures of $\frac{2}{4}$, followed by 8 measures of $\frac{3}{4}$, and finally, 8 measures of $\frac{4}{4}$. Always say “ONE” a bit louder than the rest of the beats. **Feel** the difference in the rhythm.
- Think of one or two commonly known songs (sacred or secular) that follow each of these patterns. Write down the names for the next Face-to-Face meeting.

TEMPO

The speed at which the pulse, or beat, moves is called the **tempo** (from the Latin *tempus*, meaning “time.”) A piece of music may have a slow, solemn tempo, for example:

A musical notation example showing a slow tempo. The notation is on a single staff with a common time signature (C). The tempo is indicated as $\text{♩} = 60$. The melody consists of quarter notes. The lyrics are: "Let us who mys - ti - c'ly re - pre - sent the Che - ru - bim". The notation is divided into measures by vertical bar lines. Above the staff, there are numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 1, 2, 3, 4, 1, 2, 3, 4, 1, 2, 3, 4, indicating the beat count for each measure.

Or it may have a quick, upbeat tempo:



A musical staff in common time (C) with a tempo marking of ♩ = 120. The staff contains four measures of music, each with four eighth notes. Above the staff, the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4 are written above each note in every measure. Below the staff, the lyrics "That we may re - ceive the King of all, Who comes in - vis - ib - ly up - borne" are written, with hyphens indicating syllables spanning across notes.

In the above examples, the tempo is indicated by a **metronome marking**, which indicates the number of beats per minute. In Orthodox church music, however, metronome markings are encountered relatively rarely.

TEMPO TERMS

Apart from a metronome marking, the tempo is often indicated by such Italian terms as:

Largo, Lento, or Adagio Slow tempo

Andante, Moderato, Allegretto Medium tempo

Allegro, Presto, Vivace Fast tempo

Modern-day Orthodox composers in America are just as likely to use English terms, such as, “Slowly,” “Quickly,” “With motion,” etc.

MORE TEMPO TERMS

Italian terms indicating **changes** in the tempo have become standard in the international terminology of music:

ritardando (abbreviated ***rit.***) Slowing down

rallentando (abbreviated ***rall.***) Slowing down

ritenuto (abbreviated ***riten.***) Holding back

accelerando (abbreviated ***accel.***) Speeding up

and

meno mosso With less movement, i.e., slower

più mosso With greater movement, i.e., faster

Sometimes, the above tempo terms are used with modifiers: ***poco*** = a little, or ***molto*** = a lot, for example, ***poco rit.*** (slowing down a little), or ***molto accelerando*** (speeding up a lot), etc.

COMMON TIME AND CUT TIME

The terms **common time** ($\frac{1}{1}$ or **C**) and **cut time** ($\frac{2}{2}$ or **C**) apply most readily to instrumental music and various types of popular music based on a steady, repetitive beat. Music in common time uses the quarter note as the pulse. Music in cut time uses the half note as the pulse. The examples below will illustrate the difference.

Although somewhat rare, examples of music in common time can be found in Orthodox church music. In the examples below, the pulse corresponds to the quarter note moving at a slow or moderately fast tempo (60-100 beats per minute). Each syllable of the text corresponds to one or more quarter-note pulses.

♩ = 60

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

1

Let all mor-tal flesh, let all mor-tal flesh keep si - lent

(More examples in common time)

$\text{♩} = 80$

2

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

Come let us wor - ship and fall down be - fore Christ

(Byzantine)

$\text{♩} = 100$

3

4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

O Lord save Thy peo - ple and bless Thine in - her - it - ance

To get a clearer picture of the rhythmic note values in common time, practice the examples above using Kodály rhythmic syllables. The prevailing pulse—the quarter note—corresponds to the syllable **ta**.

Example 1 with Kodály syllables:

$\text{♩} = 60$

4

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

ta ta ta ta too-oo-ee-oo ta ta ta ta too-oo too-oo too-oo-ee-oo too-oo-ee-oo

Example 2 with Kodály syllables:

$\text{♩} = 80$

5

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

too-oo ta ta ta ta ta too-oo ta ta too-oo

Example 3 with Kodály syllables:

(Byzantine)
● = 100

6

ta too-oo ta ta too-oo ta ta too-oo ta ta ta ta too-oo

• Practice Suggestion

- Go back to Examples 1 thru 3. Using a ruler or a piece of paper, cover up the words so that just the notes show. Keeping a steady beat, read the rhythm using Kodály syllables. Then check yourself, using Examples 4 thru 6.
- Be prepared to do this at the next Face-to-Face meeting.

WORD-RELATED RHYTHM AND CUT TIME

When speaking naturally, we seldom speak

one syl - la - ble at a time

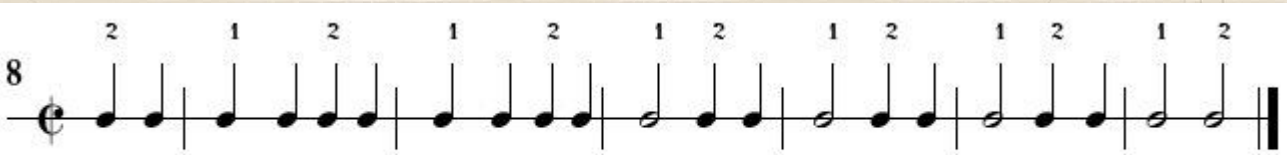
putting a beat on every sound. Instead, we group syllables into larger units, oftentimes of two or more syllables.

Because the rhythm of Orthodox church hymns is often word-related, we more frequently encounter examples that are in **cut time**: that is to say, the pulse is marked by a half note.

The syllables of the text may still correspond to quarter notes, but now, with two syllables per pulse, the text proceeds at a faster (and more natural) pace.

The image shows a musical staff in cut time (indicated by a 'C' with a vertical line through it). The tempo is marked as $\text{♩} = 80$. The melody consists of quarter notes, with two syllables per pulse. The lyrics are: "Bless-ed is the man who walks not in the coun-cil of the wick - ed". Above the staff, numbers 1 and 2 are placed above each pair of notes, indicating the syllables. The staff ends with a double bar line.

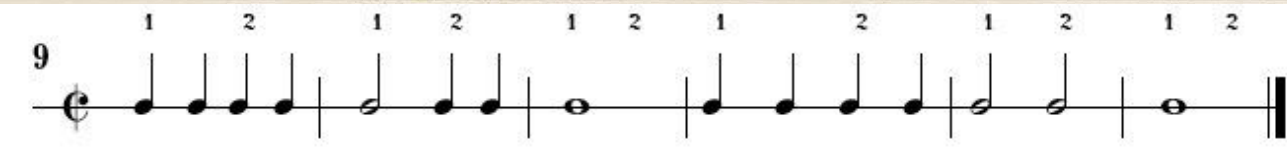
(More examples in cut time).



8

Oh, give thanks un-to the Lord, for He is good, for His mer-cy en - dur-eth for - ev - er

Detailed description: This musical example is in cut time (2/4). It begins with a treble clef and a common time signature 'C'. The melody consists of eighth notes, with some beamed in pairs. Above the staff, numbers 1 and 2 indicate the pulse for each pair of eighth notes. The lyrics are: 'Oh, give thanks un-to the Lord, for He is good, for His mer-cy en - dur-eth for - ev - er'.



9

Bless-ed is the name of the Lord hence forth and for - ev - er - more

Detailed description: This musical example is in cut time (2/4). It begins with a treble clef and a common time signature 'C'. The melody consists of eighth notes, with some beamed in pairs. Above the staff, numbers 1 and 2 indicate the pulse for each pair of eighth notes. The lyrics are: 'Bless-ed is the name of the Lord hence forth and for - ev - er - more'.

To use Kodály rhythmic syllables for learning to sight-read the rhythms of Orthodox hymns, we must first identify the prevailing pulse (quarter-note or half-note) and to assign to it the syllable **ta**. (This is a slight but necessary adaptation of Kodály's system.)

Using this approach, the rhythm of the above examples would be as follows:

$\text{♩} = 80$

10

ti ti ti ti ta ti ti ta ti ti ti ti ti ta ta

11

ti ti ti ti ti ti ti ti ta ti ti ta ti ti ta ti ti ta ta

12

ti ti ti ti ta ti ti too-oo ti ti ti ti ta ta too-oo

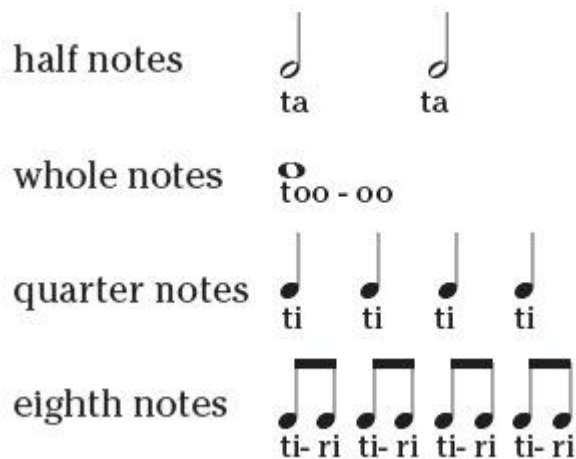
SUMMARY OF KODÁLY SYLLABLES FOR USE WITH ORTHODOX LITURGICAL HYMNS

For the purposes of the present course, we can summarize the adaptation of Kodály's rhythmic syllables in the following manner.

For hymns in which the pulse equals the quarter note:

quarter notes	 ta ta ta ta
half notes	 too - oo too - oo
whole note	 too - oo - ee - oo
eighth notes	 ti-ti ti-ti ti-ti ti-ti
sixteenth notes	 ti-ri ti-ri ti-ri ti-ri

For hymns in which the pulse equals the half note (cut time):



Since many Orthodox hymns are written without a time signature, rather than using the terms “common” or “cut” time, we can simply say “The pulse in this hymn is the quarter note” or “The pulse is the half note.”

YOU ARE NOW READY TO PRACTICE SOME MORE RHYTHMS!

Please proceed to **RHYTHM EXERCISES 2.1 & 2.2**

Name	Appearance over the centuries			
	13th	14th	15th	17th
Maxima				
Longa				
Breve				
Semibreve				
Minima				
Semiminima				
Fusa				
Semifusa				